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The Violent Existence of a “Barbie Girl in a Barbie World”: A Theoretical Analysis of the  
*Barbie* Movie

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## Abstract

The 2023 *Barbie* movie was a defining moment in media and culture, generating widespread discourse and breaking industry records. This paper critically examines *Barbie* through the theoretical framework of Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's concept of the "culture industry" as presented in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. While the film appears to engage with feminist and anti-capitalist themes, its positioning within capitalist structures complicates its ideological stance. This paper argues that the film effectively performs anti-capitalism and anti-patriarchy on behalf of its viewers, allowing them to consume its message without actively challenging the systems around them. Furthermore, *Barbie* reinforces gender essentialism and the homogenization of culture by promoting a narrow definition of individuality. Finally, the paper argues that the film masquerades as a subversion of the culture industry while effectively neutralizing any critique, thereby maintaining the hegemony of the culture industry.

The *Barbie* movie was, without a doubt, the defining “culture industry” production of 2023. It broke countless industry records, including being the largest global opening for a female-directed movie—ever.<sup>1</sup> For the months leading up to the release, predictions, memes, and general discourse dominated the internet, engaging mostly teens and young adults. *Barbie* completely captivated global consumers, even getting (negative) attention from right-wing icons like Ben Shapiro and Tucker Carlson.<sup>2</sup> Even disregarding the viewers who may lack a measure of media literacy, the ideology behind *Barbie* is difficult to pin down. As one New York Times subtitle put it: “Some critics viewed the highly-anticipated movie as satirically capitalistic, while others saw it as capitalistically satirical.”<sup>3</sup> The reviews are emphatic on both sides, which raises the question of what *Barbie* actually is. Is it a postmodern work of art? Is it a two hour Mattel advertisement that promotes complacent consumerism? Or, as many people seem to think, is it a poignant work of feminist criticism? With themes of corporate greed, consumerism, gender, being and mortality, *Barbie* is ripe for theoretical analysis.

To understand the many moving parts of the film, I want to consider Horkheimer and Adorno’s conceptualization of “the culture industry” from their 1944 book *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. On a basic level, the culture industry consists of the constellation of media and entertainment corporations who are the driving producers of what we now consider “art.” What it *does*, however, is another matter: their Marxist approach concludes that Western society has reached a point at which the production of all mass art—television, film, radio—can be traced back to the simple generation of capital; that media can no longer exist separately from the capitalist

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<sup>1</sup> Mendez, Malia. 2023. “‘Barbie’ Streaming: Records Broken at Box Office.” *Los Angeles Times*. September 12, 2023.

<sup>2</sup> Shapiro, Ben. 2023. “Ben Shapiro DESTROYS the Barbie Movie for 43 Minutes.” *YouTube*. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ynU-wVdesr0>.

<sup>3</sup> Jacobs, Julia. 2023. “‘Barbie’ Reviews Are In: Slickly Subversive or Inescapably Corporate?” *The New York Times*, 19 July 2023, <https://www.nytimes.com/2023/07/19/arts/barbie-movie-reviews.html>.

system in which it is situated.<sup>4</sup> Furthermore, the culture industry necessitates a relationship of control over its consumers, where the promise of entertainment binds consumers in mindless acceptance of the systems, relationships, and characters they are presented with.

*Barbie* is one such product of the culture industry. High-budget production by Warner Bros. and unlimited access to the best technology, costumes, actors, and creative minds makes it the epitome of the culture industry, at minimum from a technological standpoint. And just as Horkheimer and Adorno predicted, the people are entranced. Nearly 80 years after they attacked what was then emerging as popular culture, the *Barbie* movie seems to be a perfect fulfillment—in all but one area. Horkheimer and Adorno frequently gesture towards a symptom of media consumption being a “suppression of happiness,” which is primarily defined by a metaphor of sexual desire and subsequent deferment of pleasure, but defined no further. I will first be using *Dialectic of Enlightenment* as a framework to dissect and understand the particular case of *Barbie* as a product of the culture industry. Then I will be examining how, under the guise of promoting individuality, it suppresses the desire for happiness in the form of liberation from patriarchy and the gender binary.

To begin, *Barbie* disarms viewers from the onset through the mechanisms of entertainment. The premise of culture industry entertainment permeates the film down to the genre as comedy. In *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Horkheimer and Adorno write, “the spectator must need no thoughts of his own: the product prescribes each reaction, not through any actual coherence—which collapses once exposed to thought—but through signals.”<sup>5</sup> The funniest moments of *Barbie* come from exactly this kind of signaling. One of my favorite comedic

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<sup>4</sup> Adorno, Theodor W, and Max Horkheimer. 1944. *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. London: Verso.

<sup>5</sup> Leitch, Vincent B., et al. 2018. “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” *The Norton Anthology of Theory and Criticism*, W.W. Norton & Company, New York, NY, 2018, pp. 1,039.

moments in the film is after the dance party where Barbie's existential crisis begins. Ken asks to stay over because they're "boyfriend girlfriend" and Barbie counters with, "to do what?" Ken responds, "I'm actually not sure."<sup>6</sup> Of course the joke is that Barbie dolls don't have genitals, but what truly makes the audience laugh in this moment is not the dialogue, but the signals that this is supposed to be a joke. The humor lies in the long pause, Ryan Gosling's smirk, and Margot Robbie's oblivious grin—the not-so-subtle hints for the view that what's happening is written with the intention of being funny. The fact that comes through the dialogue that they don't know about sex isn't actually funny by itself. The reaction of the audience is both anticipated *and created* by the filmmakers. The way the product prescribes each reaction, however, is not unique to Barbie. What *is* unique is its blatant adherence to the mechanisms of mindless consumption.

The film further enables a lack of thought in a false replication of reality. Barbie doubles as a comedy and fantasy film, but even its fantastical elements support this false replication of reality. Horkheimer and Adorno write, "the more densely and completely its techniques duplicate empirical objects, the more easily it creates the illusion that the world outside is a seamless extension of the one which has been revealed in the cinema."<sup>7</sup> The contemporary film industry has long had the technology to capture empirical objects as such. Films now work to reproduce reality through the narrative itself, which *Barbie* does rather bluntly. In the film there are two worlds, "Barbieland" and "The Real World." At the beginning, Barbie believes Barbieland is the ultimate reality, but in traveling to The Real World, she learns that it had just been a false matriarchal reproduction. In The Real World, Ken discovers the power of patriarchy, Barbie gets sexually harassed, and there is absolutely no "girl power" at the construction site. Los Angeles,

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<sup>6</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 14:45.

<sup>7</sup> Leitch, Vincent B., et al. 2018. "Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno." *The Norton Anthology of Theory and Criticism*, W.W. Norton & Company, New York, NY, 2018, pp. 1,036.

California is the geographical representation of the real world, where some of its worst elements are condensed into a few hours of Barbie's life and a few minutes on screen. This world, in contrast with Barbieland, is recognizable to us; it feels like an extension of *our* real world. The contrast between the two worlds, then, is the mechanism to make the viewer believe that "The Real World" is the real world. The irony in this is that The Real World, despite its titular conviction, is *not* the real world. The culture industry "trains those exposed to it to identify film directly with reality. The withering of imagination need not be traced back to psychological mechanisms. The products themselves, especially the most characteristic, the sound film, cripple those faculties through their objective makeup."<sup>8</sup> Of course the patriarchy exists in reality, but it is significantly exaggerated in the film. In this way, we don't have to see the patriarchy at work ourselves, or even think about it. We just have to accept the representation we are given, where our imagination withers alongside our ability to act on these problems.

This becomes problematic when the viewer begins to believe watching Barbie is enough to combat the problems it depicts. The withering of imagination from the false reproduction of reality goes hand in hand with Mark Fisher's evaluation of the 2008 Disney/Pixar film *WALL-E*. The film implies that the destruction of the planet has come about at the fault of consumer capitalism and a mega-corporation called Buy n Large, where human minds have turned to vegetables. It's a thoroughly anti-capitalist message, but the viewers don't actually have to know that. Here, "subjugation no longer takes the form of a subordination to an extrinsic spectacle, but rather invites us to interact and participate."<sup>9</sup> The viewer can understand that this destruction is a potential outcome of capitalism, but the thinking ends there. Fisher writes, "the film performs

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<sup>8</sup> Leitch, "Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno." pp. 1,036.

<sup>9</sup> Fisher, Mark. 2022. *Capitalist Realism: Is There No Alternative?* Zer0 Books. pp. 12.

our anti-capitalism for us, allowing us to continue to consume with impunity.”<sup>10</sup> The same goes for *Barbie*. We see our own subjugation through the replication of reality, but it asks us to do absolutely nothing about it. Even worse, it plays out an entire gender war that brings to the fore all the very real problems with patriarchy, even naming exactly what takes patriarchy down. Barbie says, “by giving voice to the cognitive dissonance required to be a woman under the patriarchy you robbed it of its power!”<sup>11</sup> We imagine that we have participated in a *real* dismantling of patriarchy, when in reality, nothing has changed. *Barbie* performs our anti-capitalism and our *anti-patriarchy* for us, allowing us to continue to participate in these systems with impunity. How, though, does *Barbie* so thoroughly convince us to be okay with this?

What makes *Barbie* so hard for the average viewer to critique it is that it builds its own criticism into itself. The film is acutely aware of itself as a film, with a handful of comments that use the actors’ real names or reference itself as being a film. One such example is when Barbie is complaining about no longer being “stereotypically Barbie pretty.” The narrator interjects with, “Note to the filmmakers: Margot Robbie is the wrong person to cast if you want to make this point.”<sup>12</sup> And yet, they *did* cast Margot Robbie, and they *did* make this point. What allows them to get away with this is that they mention it. If they hadn’t included this line, viewers might have had the space to think “hmm, kind of a weird thing to say about one of the most beautiful women in Hollywood...” But instead, the film subdues its own problems by making it clear that they know they are problems. The hallmark of culture industry products, then, is the fact of their own self-consciousness: “art now dutifully admits to being a commodity, abjures its autonomy and

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<sup>10</sup> Fisher, Mark. 2022. *Capitalist Realism: Is There No Alternative?* Zer0 Books. pp. 12.

<sup>11</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:15:00.

<sup>12</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:13:15.

proudly takes its place among consumer goods.”<sup>13</sup> *Barbie* is quite literally about *dolls*, the epitome of useless commodities to be repeatedly and increasingly purchased. The film suppresses any thoughts that might criticize this by increasing the visibility of itself as a commodity. It jokes about the weird discontinued dolls like pregnant Midge, highlights a wardrobe of Barbie’s “archival” outfits, and even features animated sparkles around Barbie’s car and Dreamhouse, diverting any attention to the film as a promotion of consumption by deliberately drawing attention to the very commodities it is promoting. This metacommentary, then, becomes a tool for maintaining the viewers’ unquestioning attention to the film.

In addition to using its own self-consciousness to maintain our attention, *Barbie* works to maintain the hegemony of capitalism through self-critical anti-capitalism. The film appears to be fundamentally pro-woman; it draws striking attention to the felt impossibility of being a woman in today’s world, especially in America Ferreira’s monologue towards the end of the film, and shows the utter power that Ken has in The Real World just by being a man. This arguably contains a feminist message, which seems to encourage a desire for liberation from the patriarchy. It constantly ties its feminism to anti-capitalism, including in Sasha’s criticism of Barbie. She says, “You represent everything wrong with our culture: sexualized capitalism, unrealistic physical ideals? Look at yourself! [...] You set the feminist movement back 50 years. You destroyed girls’ innate sense of worth, and you’re killing the planet with your glorification of rampant consumerism.”<sup>14</sup> Sasha blatantly criticizes the very substance of the film, but just like the comment about casting Margot Robbie, inserting this criticism into the film is exactly what allows them to get away with making this movie.

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<sup>13</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,048

<sup>14</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 48:00.

This anti-patriarchal and anti-capitalist messaging continues throughout the film, which seems ironic for a movie whose very production relies on the continued functioning of these systems. How is this possible? In their book *The New Spirit of Capitalism*, Luc Boltanski and Ève Chiapello explore how capitalism has adapted in recent years to uphold itself while people simultaneously become aware of its violence. They write that “to maintain its powers of attraction, capitalism therefore has to draw upon resources external to it, beliefs which, at a given moment in time, possess considerable powers of persuasion, striking ideologies, even when they are considered hostile to it, inscribed in the cultural context in which it is developing.”<sup>15</sup> So then, when the CEO of Mattel is caricatured as an evil capitalist man interested only in maintaining his own power, our desire to be anti-capitalist is satisfied without actually threatening the power of the corporation or the actual CEO. Adorno and Horkheimer somehow predicted this in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*: “Those in charge no longer take much trouble to conceal the structure, the power of which increases the more bluntly its existence is admitted.”<sup>16</sup> It makes sense then that the executive board is a fundamental part of the plot, but after Will Ferrell says “now thanks to the Barbies I can relieve myself of this very heavy existential burden while hanging on to the real title of CEO” and a cheeky joke about “just wanting to have a tickle fight in board meetings,” their presence in the film, and thus any real accountability, completely falls away with no resolution.<sup>17</sup> This is primarily how *Barbie* maintains its power as a capitalist and pro-patriarchal film.

In summary, by making capitalism *fun*, *Barbie* dulls the effect of its anti-capitalism, and dulls the viewers’ ability to perform anti-capitalism at all. By making the mechanisms of

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<sup>15</sup> Boltanski, Luc, and Ève Chiapello. 2018. *The New Spirit of Capitalism*. Translated by Gregory Elliott, Verso.

<sup>16</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,033.

<sup>17</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:37:50.

comedic entertainment, false replication of reality, self-criticism and false anti-capitalism unconventionally girly, colorful, and hilarious, *Barbie* safely maintains its role as a damaging product of the contemporary culture industry. Horkheimer and Adorno argue cynically about the power of fun: “Fun is a medicinal bath which the entertainment industry never ceases to prescribe. It makes laughter the instrument for cheating happiness.”<sup>18</sup> We’ve seen how *Barbie* maintains the power of its creators, but it does more than *be fun* to cheat its viewers of happiness.

*Barbie*, under the guise of promoting individuality, actually aids the process of homogenizing society and limiting individual freedoms. According to Horkheimer and Adorno, another symptom of the ascendance of the culture industry is the homogenization of culture, by converting the individual subject to mere consumer. As customers, people “are regaled, whether on the screen or in the press, with human interest stories demonstrating freedom of choice and the charm of not belonging to the system [...] they remain objects”<sup>19</sup> As a product, *Barbie* is marketed to women regardless of class, race, or other designations of identity. It takes no real political stance that might divide them, and in this way creates a consumer body unified under the singular premise of girl power. To hide this, a concluding message of the film is that to find comfort in being imperfect beings, we must find our individuality. The solution to the Barbies vs. Kens gender war comes when Barbie encourages Ken that “you’re not your girlfriend, you’re not your house, you’re not your mink.”<sup>20</sup> Instead of “Barbie and Ken,” she suggests “maybe all the things you thought made you *you* aren’t really you. Maybe it’s *Barbie* ...and it’s *Ken*.” The irony of this message lies just below the surface: millions of consumers watch this scene equally, perhaps even inspired to find who they are apart from their own habits of consumption. What’s

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<sup>18</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,041.

<sup>19</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,044.

<sup>20</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:35:40.

more is that with the medium of film, there is what Horkheimer and Adorno called “no mechanism of reply”—there is no way for viewers to respond or interact with this scene; no way for their individuality to be validated.<sup>21</sup> Instead, viewers sit silently in front of the screen, universally uplifted through the false promise that they have power as the individuals they are.

Furthermore, *Barbie* activates the desire for liberation from patriarchy then subsequently denies it. Horkheimer and Adorno notice a pattern within the film industry of provoking desire for happiness then denying it, which they explain with a bit of a crude analogy (or perhaps it *is* literal, but applicable either way) of sexual desire. They conclude: “the mass production of sexuality automatically brings about its repression.”<sup>22</sup> So while happiness is constantly being gestured towards, we never fully see it or are able to claim it for ourselves.

The entire *Barbie* film feels as though it is building up to some sort of climax where the women are liberated from the oppression of the patriarchy, and they are—but only in Barbieland. In Barbieland, men (Kens) finally leave women (Barbies) alone, satisfied with discovering who they are without relying on the subjugation of women. This is nice to watch, of course, but this happiness is only satisfied in a fantasy replication of the real world, suggesting it’s not actually possible in our real world. Again, the film hardly tries to hide this denial of happiness. Early in the film, Barbie confesses to Ruth, the creator of Barbie: “The real world isn’t what I thought it was.” She responds, “It never is. And isn’t that marvelous?”<sup>23</sup> This is a bit perplexing, because this conversation directly follows Barbie’s discovery of the true violence of patriarchy. The implication is, then, that we are supposed to be satisfied with a perpetual possibility for this violence to occur—and that that variety is marvelous. The *Barbie* movie assures us that we will

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<sup>21</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,034.

<sup>22</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,040.

<sup>23</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 50:50.

always be subject to the control of the patriarchy, and in this way suppresses a desire to be freed from it.

By portraying gender as an inherent boundary of being human, *Barbie* enforces what theorist Marquis Bey calls a “violence of circumscription.” Much of the second half of the film is spent convincing the viewer that what makes women *women* is that they can be anything. Gloria asks the CEO of Mattel to create an “ordinary Barbie”—one that is “just a mom, because it’s okay to just want to be a mom.”<sup>24</sup> Womanhood is converted to a concept, rather than being something innate—but *Barbie* ends on an oddly essentialist note: Barbie chooses to move to The Real World and become a Real Woman, which she substantiates in the final scene by going to the gynecologist. To truly be a woman, she must have a vagina. The gendered violence does not end here, however. In their essay “The Coalition of Gender Abolition,” Marquis Bey explains why they think gender should be abolished: “underlying it is a violence of separation and exclusion, a violence of circumscription.”<sup>25</sup> Labels like “woman” “man” or “non-binary” constitute a kind of “prison,” which “requires that those for whom the identity is definitional only *be* inasmuch as they measure up to the identity and, most crucially, do not permit themselves to be other than the identity which commits an atrocious monopolizing of how one can emerge as a subject.”<sup>26</sup> The *Barbie* movie is fundamentally invested in upholding these limitations to subject formation, because its selling point that all viewers are individuals, not a single mass of consumers, is founded on the idea that “it’s *Barbie* ...and it’s *Ken*.”<sup>27</sup> There is no in-between, or experimentation, or being just You allowed. Barbie and Ken represent the only two models for

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<sup>24</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:38:00.

<sup>25</sup> Bey, Marquis. 2022. “The Coalition of Gender Abolition.” *CISTEM Failure: Essays on Blackness and Cisgender*, Duke University Press, Durham, NC. pp. 130.

<sup>26</sup> Bey, “The Coalition of Gender Abolition.” pp. 134.

<sup>27</sup> *Barbie*. 2023. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Entertainment Inc. 1:35:50.

how to emerge as a subject (excluding the excuse for LGBTQ+ representation that is Allan), and the “pseudoindividuality” that emerges from the dominance of the culture industry relies on the existence of these boundaries. The film, and the culture industry as a whole, enforce boundaries of being in the interest of maintaining its power.

And it could go on and on. Everything in the *Barbie* movie is deeply entrenched in capitalist ideology, and even though we can hope the feminist and anti-capitalist messages are genuine, they never will be. Horkheimer and Adorno write, “The power of their true master is the purpose of all films, regardless of the plot selected by the production directors.”<sup>28</sup> The power of Mattel is the true purpose of *Barbie*. The power of patriarchy and capitalism is the true purpose. The framework of the culture industry helps us think about how a movie like *Barbie* uses common mechanisms to hide the fact that maintaining that power is the purpose, and in doing so continues to repress desire for liberation from the gendered structures of patriarchy and the gender binary.

And what about the material consequences of the *Barbie* movie? Mattel reported a 16% rise in toy sales after the movie’s release, which is not insignificant, but as Mattel CEO (the real one, not Will Ferrell) Ynon Kreiz said in an interview “this was not about making a movie, this was about creating an iconic cultural moment.”<sup>29</sup> This movie was never about selling Barbie dolls. It was about selling ideas. Some might, and many do, argue that injecting feminist and anti-capitalist rhetoric into a blockbuster film begins to make a step in the right direction for

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<sup>28</sup> Leitch, “Max Horkheimer and Theodor W. Adorno.” pp. 1,035.

<sup>29</sup> Richardson, Drew. 2023. “Mattel Says Barbie Sales Grew 16% as Blockbuster Movie Became a Phenomenon.” *CNBC*, 26 Oct. 2023, [www.cnbc.com/2023/10/25/mattel-mat-q3-earnings-barbie-sales-surge.html](http://www.cnbc.com/2023/10/25/mattel-mat-q3-earnings-barbie-sales-surge.html).; Coleman, Julie. 2023. “Mattel CEO Talks Barbie’s Official Big Screen Debut: ‘This Was Not about Making a Movie, This Was about Creating an Iconic Cultural Moment.’” *CNBC*, 20 July 2023, [www.cnbc.com/2023/07/19/mattel-ceo-talks-barbies-official-big-screen-debut.html](http://www.cnbc.com/2023/07/19/mattel-ceo-talks-barbies-official-big-screen-debut.html).

overthrowing the systems that perpetuate inequality and violence. In response, I would borrow Audre Lorde's pervasive motto: the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house.<sup>30</sup>

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<sup>30</sup> Lorde, Audre. "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House." *Sister Outsider*, Penguin Books, New York, NY, 2020.

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